

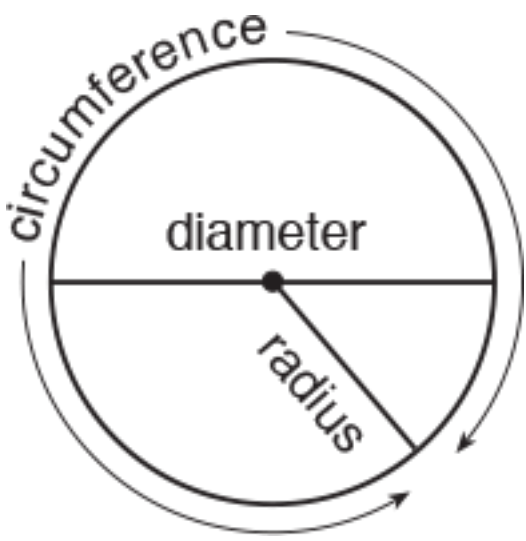
Circumference

A **circle** is a set of closed points in a plane. Every point on a circle is the same distance from the center.

The distance around a circle is called the **circumference**. Measuring the circumference of a circle is challenging because you can't use a ruler to measure something round. But you can measure the distance straight across.

The **diameter** is a line segment that passes through the center of a circle. Drawing a diameter cuts the circle into two equal halves.

Half of the diameter is the **radius**. The radius is the distance from the center to any point on the circle.



You can approximate circumference using a relationship that exists between the circumference of a circle and its diameter. Whatever the size of the circle, the circumference is always a little more than 3 times the diameter.

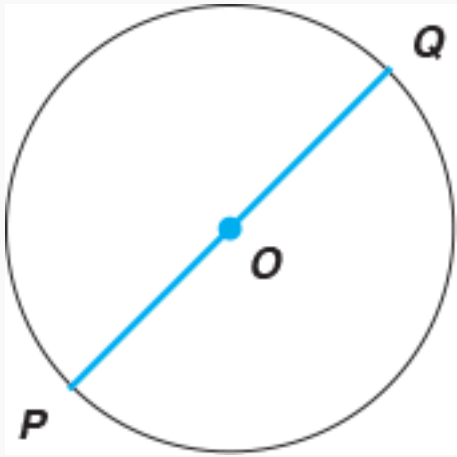
The ratio of the circumference to the diameter is called **pi**, represented by the Greek letter π . The value of π is about 3.14. Pi can be used to write formulas for finding the circumference and area of circles. You should memorize these formulas. They will not be listed on the GED math formula sheet.

Circumference (C) of a Circle $C = \pi d$, where d = diameter

Example

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What is the circumference of a circle when PQ equals 12 inches?



PQ is the diameter: $d = 12$

The radius is half the diameter: $r = 6$

Use the circumference formula:

$$C = \pi d$$

$$\approx 3.14 \cdot 12$$

$$\approx \mathbf{37.68 \text{ inches}}$$

Key Terms

circumference

diameter

radius

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Lesson 3: Circles and
Complex Figures

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